BRISKET AND CARAMELIZED ONION FILLING

INGREDIENTS

27 g	Salt
912 g	Brisket, center cut with a moderate amount of fat
56 g	Olive oil
1.85 kg	Onions, cut into 1/8-inch slices
2 sprigs	Thyme
474 g	Water
30 g	Parmigiano-reggiano, finely grated
quantity not given	Nutmeg, whole

METHOD

1. Salt the brisket all over. Give it an hour at minimum to take the salt up, or refrigerate it as long as 24 hours. Bring it back to room temperature before it goes near heat.
2. Heat the oven to 275°F.
3. Pat the brisket dry to take off any surface moisture. Warm 42 g of the oil in a large saute pan over medium heat and sear the brisket fat side down 4 to 5 minutes, until the fat starts to melt and turns golden brown. Sear the remaining sides 4 to 5 minutes each, turning as needed, then move it to a sheet pan.
4. Spread half the onions over the base of a heavy lidded saucepot or Dutch oven. Lay the brisket on them, pile the rest of the onions over the top, and lay the thyme on the onions. Pour in the water, seal the pot with foil or parchment, and clamp the lid down over the seal.
5. Cook 5 to 6 hours, until the meat pulls apart easily under a fork. By then the onions will have collapsed and caramelized into a jus, which becomes the base of the sauce.
6. While that happens, chill the meat grinder and its small die in the refrigerator at least 1 hour, or 30 minutes in the freezer.
7. Take the pot out, uncover it, and spoon off whatever fat has risen. Leave the brisket in the pot about 20 minutes, until it is cool enough to handle.
8. Lift the brisket onto a sheet pan. Strain the cooking liquid, keeping the solids and the liquid separate and squeezing the onions hard so none of the liquid stays behind. You should end up with 150 g of onions and 474 g of liquid. Set both aside.
9. Pick the meat into small pieces and discard the fat. Grind the meat through the small die, then grind the braised onions.
10. Combine the meat and onions in a bowl with the parmigiano and the remaining 14 g of oil. Season with grated nutmeg and salt and mix well. Aim for properly seasoned. Cover it and refrigerate.
11. Take the filling out of the refrigerator about 30 minutes before you use it. It handles much better at room temperature.

NOTES

The braise yields two things. The strained solids become the filling and the 474 g of strained liquid becomes the sauce, so do not discard either.
275°F for 5 to 6 hours under a sealed lid cooks the meat in three stages in sequence, roasting first, then steaming, then braising as the onions melt.
Squeeze the onions hard at the straining step. Liquid left in them is volume taken off the sauce.
Cold filling is stiff and tears pasta sheets. The 30 minutes at room temperature is worth waiting for.
1.85 kg of onion to 912 g of brisket looks wrong and is not. The onion is the sweetness in both the filling and the sauce.

DATE ___ / ___ / ___ RATING ___ / 5 OVEN ADJ _____

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